manifestation of Vishnu's consort Lakshmi, having undergone an elevation from obscurity in the Vedas to centre stage in the Puranas.

Lastly, to Vedic geography and what it tells us about roots.

I have described the Narmada River as the boundary between the two Indias. Today it is firmly entrenched in Hindu tradition as one of the *Saptasindhu*, the seven sacred rivers of India. Devotional hymns to these seven rivers, also known as the *Saptapunyanadi* or 'seven auspicious rivers', are a feature of daily worship for a great many Hindus, with no doubts as to which these seven rivers are. Three of the seven – the Ganges (Ganga), the Jumna (Yamuna) and the Indus (Sindhu) – water the North; two – the Godavari and the Kaveri – water the South; and the Narmada waters the middle. The seventh river is that most beguiling and mysterious of rivers, the Saraswati.

No river receives more adulation in the *R-V* than the Saraswati, where she is described as 'best mother, best river, best goddess', and as 'surpassing in majesty and might all other rivers, pure in her course from the mountains to the ocean'. Book 6 of the *R-V* is considered among the earliest and it includes the hymn known as the *Saraswati Sukta*, full of praises for the river's power and virtues. 'Most dear amid dear streams, seven-sistered, graciously inclined, Sarasvati hath earned our praise,' reads part of Ralph Griffith's translation. She is described as 'sprung from threefold source', 'the Five Tribes' prosperer', and 'marked out by majesty among the Mighty Ones, in glory swifter than the other rapid streams'. So patently, the Saraswati was a river of huge significance to the authors of *R-V* 6 – and with good cause, because we are told that it was on her banks that the sacred language of Sanskrit was received from the gods and where the first hymns to the gods were composed. Indeed, the Saraswati River defined the very heartland of the Arya as Brahmavarta, the 'land of Brahma's people'.